

The Seleucids were victims of their own initial success. Their sprawling empire was too large and too diverse to hold together.

THE END OF THE SELEUCIDS

In the 2nd century BCE the Seleucids were driven from Persia and Mesopotamia by the **Parthians 122–23 >>**. By 100 BCE the empire had been reduced to Antioch and a few other Syrian cities. They continued to exist only because powers such as Rome **106–15 >>** and the **Ptolemaic dynasty 118–21 >>** in Egypt did not see them as a serious threat. It was the Roman general **Pompey** who finally put an end to the Seleucid Empire, annexing Syria as a Roman province in 64 BCE.

THE PARTHIAN EMPIRE

The end of the Seleucid Empire left the Romans and the Parthians to contest the Middle East. When the Romans tried to invade Mesopotamia in 53 BCE, the Parthians defeated them at **Carrhae**, but the Romans had the better of later clashes, sacking the

Parthian capital of **Ctesiphon** three times in the 2nd century CE. The Parthians, originally a semi-nomadic steppe people, left much of the administrative structure of the Seleucid empire intact—coins with Greek inscriptions were minted as late as the 2nd century CE. All this changed after the Parthians were ousted by the Persian **Sassanids 122–23 >>** in 236 CE.

GRAECO-BUDDHIST ART

Aspects of Hellenistic culture also survived farther east, in **Bactria** (in Afghanistan) and parts of northern India such as Gandhara. Between the 2nd century BCE and the 4th century CE many sculptures from Bactria and the so-called **Indo-Greek kingdoms 124–25 >>** display a combination of the artistic styles of India, Persia, and Greece.



GREEK-INFLUENCED BUDDHA; BACTRIA, 3RD CENTURY CE

East meets West in Nemrud Dag, Turkey

In the 1st century BCE, the king of Commagene, Antiochus I, built a mountain-top shrine where the fine statuary depicts both Greek and Persian deities and uses a combination of eastern and western artistic styles.

embracing Macedonia, Greece, Egypt, and all the Persian territory he had conquered in Asia.

According to Plutarch's biography of Alexander, written nearly 400 years after the event, his body lay in its coffin for several days without showing any signs of decay, while his generals argued over who should succeed him.

The body, an important talisman for Alexander's potential successors, was embalmed to be taken home, but it was diverted to Alexandria in Egypt, where it was exhibited in a glass case.



Bactrian deities

This plate from Ai Khanoum (in modern Afghanistan) shows the Greek goddess Cybele in a chariot pulled by lions in front of a Persian priest at a fire altar.

Ptolemaic kingdom (see pp.118–19), which ruled Egypt and Palestine. It lasted until 30 BCE, when in the reign of Cleopatra VII (see pp.120–21), it was annexed by Rome. The largest of the successor states, however, was the Seleucid Empire, founded in 312 BCE by Seleucus I Nicator, when he secured Babylon and with it control of Persia, Mesopotamia, Syria, and much of Anatolia.

The three empires spread Greek ideas through their political institutions, town planning, and architecture. They were eager to show that they preserved the cultural freedoms of the Hellenic ideal, so the cities they built had all the attributes of a Greek city-state: an agora, or place for public debate, temples to all or one God, and spectacular theaters.

Greek culture in Asia

The Seleucid empire established many Greek-style cities to help control their huge territory. Seleucus I had a new capital, Seleucia, built in Mesopotamia, on the Tigris, near Babylon, but the capital was soon moved to Antioch in Syria. The Seleucids had a relaxed attitude to the religions practiced in their territories, and Greek ideas were accepted alongside old Persian, Jewish, and other local traditions.

In the course of the 3rd century BCE, the Seleucids had to abandon their eastern provinces of Bactria and Parthia, but that did not mean the end of Greek influence there. The distant Bactrian kingdom (in present-day Afghanistan) retained a magnificent Greek coinage, and archaeological sites such as Ai Khanoum (thought to be the city of Alexandria on the Oxus) reveal that Bactrian cities continued to follow Greek models with temples and other public buildings fronted by beautiful Corinthian columns.

To the west of the Seleucid sphere of influence, in present-day Turkey, Pergamum, an important new regional

power, was emerging. Attalus I Soter, who ruled 241–197 BCE, took the title of king of Pergamum and made his city into a major center for literature, philosophy, and the arts. It had its own acropolis, magnificent temples, a theater seating 10,000 people, and a vast library. Another fascinating Hellenistic state

HELLENISTIC The three centuries after Alexander's death in 323 BCE are called the Hellenistic Age, when post-Classical Greek culture spread far beyond its homeland. Greek ideas and artistic styles were adopted in Asia, Egypt, and, most importantly, Rome.

was Commagene in the southeast of present-day Turkey, which broke away from the Seleucids around 162 BCE. It absorbed Persian influences from the east and Greek from the west. Antiochus I,

who ruled from 70–38 BCE, built a monument to himself at Nemrud Dag, which is the most extraordinary fusion of Hellenism and Eastern culture.

Wars of succession

Alexander's wife Roxana had a son in August 332 BCE, but he never grew up to succeed his father—he was killed in 310 by one of the generals competing to take over the empire. Alexander had told his commanders that the succession lay with the “fittest.” Bloody conflict to determine who this would be raged almost continuously from 323 to 279 BCE. By then, three main Hellenistic states had been established. The smallest was the Antigonid kingdom, which ruled in Macedonia and Greece. Constantly involved in wars with the Greek city-states (see pp.94–95), it eventually fell to Rome (see pp.106–15) in 168 BCE. The richest and most secure was the

IDEA

PHILHELLENISM

Admiration for Greek philosophy, poetry, and sculpture survives to this day, although it probably peaked in 18th- and 19th-century Europe. *The Apotheosis of Homer* (right) by Antonio Canova (1757–1822) embodies the spirit of admiration for Classical Greece. Philhellenism (love of Greek culture and the belief that theirs was the perfect way to order society) takes no account of the fact that Greek women had no vote or that Greek society depended on the labor of slaves.

